HEALTHY HABITS

Making a plan to stop smoking

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

How can you get help to quit?

Stopping smoking helps protect your heart. Nicotine dependence can make quitting difficult, and needing support is common. Counseling and suitable medicines can help. Ask your doctor or rehabilitation team which options fit your health and treatment. You do not have to rely on willpower alone. [1,2,3]

Understand your smoking pattern

Write down when you usually smoke and what is happening at those times. A cigarette might follow coffee, a meal, stress, or time with friends. Identifying these situations can help you plan a different response. Be honest about how much you use and about other tobacco or nicotine products. An honest record helps the team plan suitable support.

Prepare a quit date

Choose a date with your team and decide what support you will need. Think about cigarettes, lighters, and the places where you usually smoke. Let people close to you know how they can help. Ask them not to offer cigarettes or smoke near you. Make a simple plan for the first difficult moment, such as calling a supporter or following an approved coping strategy. [1]

Discuss medicines safely

Nicotine replacement and other prescribed treatments may be options. Ask a clinician or pharmacist which treatment is appropriate and how to use it. Mention your heart medicines, past reactions, and mental health concerns. Do not combine products or copy another person’s dose without advice. Ask what side effects need a call and what requires urgent care. Keep the instructions with your other medicine information. [1,2,4]

Expect to revise the plan

If you smoke after your quit date, tell your team and look at what happened. A lapse can show where more support is needed. It does not mean that further effort is useless. Identify the trigger, review your treatment, and agree on the next action. Avoid hiding the problem because you are embarrassed. Accurate information helps the team work with you. [2]

Make your surroundings supportive

Ask household members about keeping shared indoor spaces free of smoke. Plan a response to friends who invite you to smoke during a visit or break. You could prepare a short explanation and suggest another activity. If stress is a strong trigger, ask about counseling or stress support. Choose alternatives that fit your approved activity and food plan rather than creating a new health problem.

Follow up on progress

Discuss cravings, questions, and barriers at follow-up. If the plan is not helping, ask about more counseling or another treatment approach. Ask about local support; telephone numbers on overseas websites may not serve the Philippines.

References

1. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Cardiac rehabilitation and quitting smoking. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/cardiac-rehab/taking-care-of-yourself/cardiac-rehabilitation-and-quitting-smoking

2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (n.d.). How to quit smoking. https://www.cdc.gov/tobacco/campaign/tips/quit-smoking/index.html

3. National Health Service. (n.d.). Quit smoking. https://www.nhs.uk/live-well/quit-smoking/

4. World Health Organization. (n.d.). Tobacco and nicotine. https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/tobacco

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Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
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